

moved, whether you own your own home, how often you take out cash advances, how close you are to your credit limits, what kinds of things you buy on credit, how many credit cards you have, and past payment history. A computer compares this information to patterns from thousands of other consumers and predicts your level of credit risk.

For a fee, you can now obtain your credit score, or FICO score, named after the Fair Isaac Corporation, the company that developed credit scoring and the largest provider of credit scores to creditors and financial institutions. While there are other credit scores out there, the FICO credit score is most often used by lenders and others. All three major credit bureaus offer this option with your credit report or as a separate option.

To get your FICO score directly from Fair Isaac, visit www.myfico.com. Their website also provides details on how the score is composed, and what you can do to improve it. Some of the more common ideas put forth to improve your credit include keeping current with your bills, keeping credit card balances low, avoiding the practice of paying down one credit card by borrowing from another credit card, avoiding the closure of unused credit cards and the opening of new credit cards, and checking your credit report for any inaccuracies.